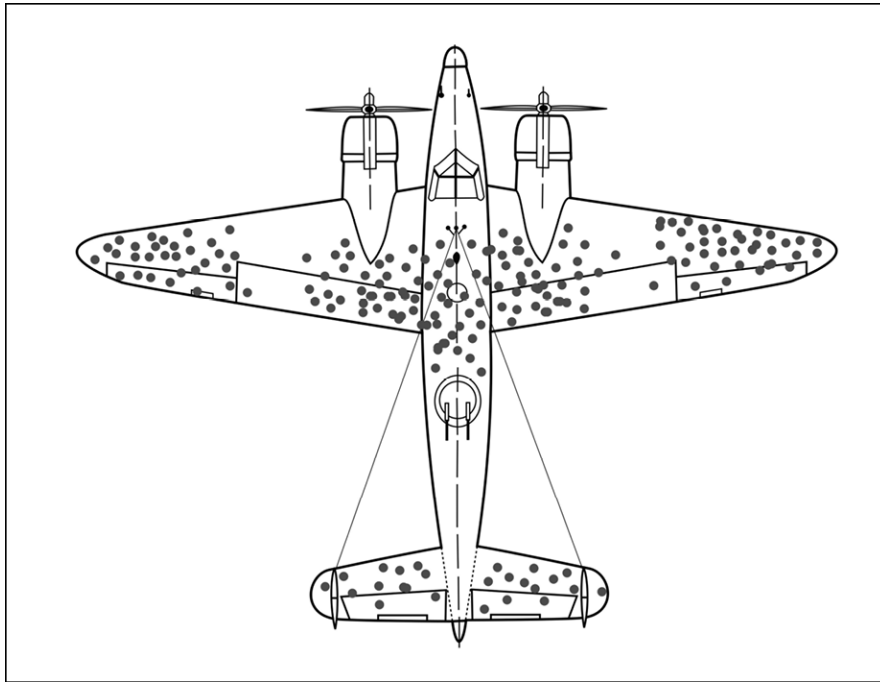


The Hidden World of Failure: What if **EVERYTHING** is survivorship bias?

YOU MAY RECOGNIZE this image. It is a World War Two bomber, showing a composite of where American planes returning to base had taken fire during their bombing runs.



This was of concern to the US military. Senior brass went to the Statistical Research Group (SRG), “a classified program that yoked the assembled might of American statisticians to the war effort—something like the Manhattan Project, except the weapons being developed were equations not explosives.”¹³⁸ The generals wanted to improve the survivability of their bombers by adding more armor. The trade-off was greater fuel consumption, and reduced range, speed, and maneuverability. Exactly how much armor got added (and where) was crucial to the success of the war effort.

Abraham Wald was an Austrian mathematician and a Jew who had been